VOC's idealism was oral lore even in those days. Subramania Bharati, who noted the initial difficulties in acquiring the ships, wrote that VOC had vowed not to return to Tuticorin without a steamer.[42] Despite his firstborn Olaganathan's serious illness at that time, VOC refused to return until the task was accomplished.[43] To add to his anxiety, VOC's wife Meenakshi was heavy with child, and their second son was born on 29 December when VOC was in the thick of steamer acquisition. In gratitude to S.T.A. Arumugam Pillai, a Tuticorin trader and director of SSNCo who assisted the family at this crucial moment, VOC—following a Tamil convention—named his son after him.

These were frenzied months for VOC, and his mind was occupied with a thousand things as he was trying to build the Swadeshi movement, promote a company, chivvy traders, reassure businessmen, galvanize investors and shareholders and deal in big money, not to speak of inspiring the common people for his political project. Fortunately, some letters of that period have survived. Many of them are in his secretary's hand—immersed in work VOC was dictating letters rather than writing them himself. Apparently, he did not have access to a typewriter. Here is a letter, to a Tuticorin-based businessman, that indicates his preoccupations and the consequent confusion in attending to correspondence:

> I have entirely forgotten to write to you till my gumastah's letter reached me this noon wherein I found that one of your telegrams was returned undelivered. I beg your pardon for the same. I was thinking to write to you on so many matters & I then thought in my half absentmindedness that I had written to you. To-day when I thought over the matter calmly, I came to know that I did not write to you.

The purchase of steamers was taking time with unexpected difficulties cropping up and was most likely not going ahead as planned. A pious man, VOC put his faith in the almighty, and continued:

> Be sure that I will return to Tuticorin with two beautiful new steamers of twenty knots speed. It may take a month more for the steamers to come into our hands. You need not be anxious where I will get money for the purchase of two steamers simultaneously & other such matters. God has promised to give me whatever money I require for the cause of the country.